

The Webb. A central number that you could call and talk to a person who could do anything for you that you could do online.

Web Macros. A way to record sequences of steps on websites so that you could repeat common actions, even across sites, and share “recipes” for how you accomplished online tasks.

Internet Button Company. A way to package steps taken on a website and smart form-fill functionality. People could encode buttons and share buttons à la social bookmarking.

Max and Damon had a vision that computers could be used to create a virtual personal assistant to which their customers could ask questions. Because the assistant was designed for subjective questions, the answers required human judgment. Thus, the early Aardvark experiments tried many variations on this theme, building a series of prototypes for ways customers could interact with the virtual assistant and get their questions answered. All the early prototypes failed to engage the customers.

As Max describes it, “We self-funded the company and released very cheap prototypes to test. What became Aardvark was the sixth prototype. Each prototype was a two- to four-week effort. We used humans to replicate the back end as much as possible. We invited one hundred to two hundred friends to try the prototypes and measured how many of them came back. The results were unambiguously negative until Aardvark.”

Because of the short time line, none of the prototypes involved advanced technology. Instead, they were MVPs designed to test a more important question: what would be required to get customers to engage with the product and tell their friends about it?

“Once we chose Aardvark,” Ventilla says, “we continued to run